

Botticelli

Following an apprenticeship as a goldsmith, Sandro Botticelli (c.1444–1510) studied painting with Lippi and Verrocchio. His graceful, ornamental and linear style relied on constructing compositions with line rather than tonal contrasts, a delicate approach echoing elements of Gothic art.

One of the first Renaissance painters to create large, elegant mythological and religious pictures, Botticelli's work reflected Lorenzo de' Medici's fascination with Neoplatonism and new ideas by the philosopher Marsilio Ficino (1433–99). *The Birth of Venus*, c.1482 and *La Primavera*, 1477–82, are filled with symbolism and scholarly ideas. His female figures are always similar – slender-bodied, with large eyes, somewhat melancholy expressions and flowing blonde hair – a look that was influential on Art Nouveau in the late 19th century. In later years, influenced by the Dominican friar Savonarola, he painted only religious works. Aside from two years in Rome painting the Sistine Chapel walls, he remained in Florence all his life.



Botticelli, *La Primavera*, 1477–82